

Examining Assumptions of Generative
AI–Enabled Strategy Execution in
Brand-Driven Organizations

by

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Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Introduction: Strategy Execution and Organizational Contexts

Strategy execution, which is the translation of strategic intent into coordinated organizational action (Hrebiniak, 2006), has traditionally focused on resource allocation, structural alignment, and performance monitoring (Bower, 1970; Mintzberg, 1978). Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) challenges these frameworks by fundamentally reconfiguring how organizations allocate attention, distribute decision-making authority, and coordinate action (Laamanen et al., 2025; Vera et al., 2026). This marks a shift from viewing GenAI as automating discrete tasks to recognizing its capacity to reshape basic mechanisms of **strategy** execution **itself**.

Recent scholarship positions GenAI as expanding organizational attention by broadening the range of issues firms can simultaneously attend to, accelerating feedback loops between analysis and action, and redistributing attention across organizational actors (Laamanen et al., 2025). This transforms execution from a bounded, hierarchically managed process into a distributed, temporally compressed, and analytically intensive **one**. The dominant assumption is that GenAI improves execution capacity by reducing temporal lags between issue recognition and enabling continuous strategic adjustment. However, this emerging literature rests on particular assumptions about what constitutes high-quality execution. These assumptions are centered on speed, analytical optimization, and coordination efficiency (Deloitte, 2025; McKinsey & Company, 2025; Neiroukh et al., 2024). These assumptions reflect an efficiency-oriented logic of organizing that prioritizes optimization and control as the primary dimensions of execution quality. Whether these assumptions hold across all organizational contexts remains an open empirical question.

This chapter examines these assumptions within brand-driven organizations, where execution quality also depends not only on operational efficiency but also on identity coherence, symbolic consistency, and meaning preservation (Balmer & Podnar, 2021; Urde, 1999). Section 2.2 establishes brand-driven organizations as strategic contexts with distinctive execution priorities. Section 2.3 analyzes dominant assumptions in GenAI-execution literature. Section 2.4 develops three **theoretical tensions** between efficiency-oriented and identity-oriented execution logics. Section 2.5 identifies the research gap and positions this study's contribution.

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Commented [JL3]: But couldn't automation actually also be strategic (see Seidl et al, 2024)? Be careful in framing.

Commented [JL4]: Ref, Ref, Ref... You will reference almost every sentence, generally with multiple sources.

Commented [JL5]: Evidence?

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2.2 Brand Driven Organizations as Strategic Contexts

2.2.1 Defining Brand-Driven Organizations

Brand-driven organizations are those in which brand identity functions as a primary strategic resource constraining decision-making and guiding execution across functions and over time (Balmer, 2012; Urde, 1999; Urde & Koch, 2014). In such organizations, the brand is not a downstream communication output but an upstream organizing device shaping which actions are considered appropriate, legitimate, and executable (Balmer, 2017; Csaba & Bengtsson, 2006). This orientation distinguishes brand-driven organizations from product-driven or market-driven firms. While product-driven organizations prioritize functional innovation and market-driven firms prioritize customer responsiveness (Urde, 1999), brand-driven organizations subordinate both to identity coherence. Strategic decisions are evaluated not only by their market or operational consequences but by what they signify about “who we are” as an organization (Aaker, 1996; Balmer & Gray, 2003; Gioia et al., 2013).

Brand-driven orientation is particularly pronounced in contexts where competitive advantage depends on reputational capital, stakeholder trust, and long-term differentiation. Examples include luxury good firms (Kapferer & Bastien, 2009), heritage brands (Urde et al., 2007), and value-driven organizations (Vallaster & de Chernatony, 2006), and professional service firms where brand reputation is the primary asset (von Nordenflycht, 2010). In such contexts, brand coherence operates as both a strategic resource and a constraint on execution.

Critically, brand-driven orientation is not determined by the industry but is a strategic choice (Urde, 1999). Sustained investments in brand identity, internal alignment mechanisms, and stakeholder expectations make deviation increasingly costly over time (Gioia et al., 2013; Hatch & Schultz, 2002). Organizations develop identity preservation routines, employee socialization processes, and quality control mechanisms explicitly designed to maintain brand consistency (Iglesias et al., 2013; Punjaisri & Wilson, 2011). As a result, execution in brand-driven organizations faces stronger symbolic and normative constraints than in efficiency-oriented firms.

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Commented [JL10]: So, brand as core competence?

Commented [JL11]: This would need to be how you open the section, rather than focusing on brand only.

Commented [JL12]: Unclear. Strategic decision. Strategic resource. Strategic investment. What exactly is it? :)

2.2.2 Identity Logic and Execution Priorities

To understand how brand-driven firms prioritize execution differently from efficiency-oriented firms, this study draws on institutional logic theory. Institutional logics are socially constructed belief systems that provide actors with principles for organizing, evaluating actions, and defining success (Thornton et al., 2015). They shape what counts as legitimate action, which criteria are prioritized in decision-making, and how accountability is enacted. Organizations often operate under multiple logics simultaneously, creating tensions when these logics prescribe contradictory evaluation criteria (Besharov & Smith, 2014; Pache & Santos, 2013). Prior research shows that when efficiency-oriented and identity-oriented logics coexist, organizations must actively manage competing demands through structural separation, temporal sequencing, or symbolic reconciliation (Battilana & Dorado, 2010).

Commented [JL13]: On institutional theory, specifically the notion of institutional logics. (Incidentally, this is a bit disconnected from you framing in strategy-as-practice / execution, which is practice theoretical)...

In brand-driven organizations, execution operates under an identity logic that is related to coherence with organizational identity, value alignment, and symbolic consistency (Balmer, 2017; Gioia et al., 2013; Ravasi & Schultz, 2006). Under this logic, execution quality is evaluated not only by what actions accomplish operationally but also by what they signify about organizational character. Actions that violate identity expectations may be rejected even when they are analytically optimal or economically advantageous (Dutton & Dukerich, 1991; Hsu & Hannan, 2005). This contrasts with the efficiency logic that dominates GenAI-execution literature, where legitimacy derives from performance improvement, analytical optimization, and competitive advantage (Laamanen et al., 2025; Neiroukh et al., 2024). Under efficiency logic, execution quality is measured through temporal compression, analytical comprehensiveness, and coordination effectiveness. These two logics are not mutually exclusive, but they prioritize different dimensions of execution. Table 2.1 summarizes their key differences:

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Table 2.1: Efficiency Logic vs. Identity Logic in Strategy Execution

Dimension	Efficiency Logic	Identity Logic
Primary Legitimacy source	Performance Optimization, competitive advantage	Identity coherence, symbolic consistency

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1. AI matters in strategy execution
2. It will matter differently in different organizations
3. Conditions of brand orgs have not been adequately theorized; will not hold here

At the moment you start with strategy execution, jump to brand orgs with little justification, and then start throwing AI assumptions in ;) Take the argument slowly, step by step.

Decision Evaluation Criteria	Speed, analytical rigor, cost-effectiveness	Appropriateness, meaning alignment, authenticity
Temporal Orientation	Acceleration, real-time responsiveness	Deliberate pacing, consistency over time
Knowledge Basis	Data-driven analytics, pattern recognition	Interpretive judgment, tacit knowledge, heritage
Coordination Mechanism	Structural governance, role specification	Ongoing dialogue, collective sensemaking
Accountability Basis	Procedural compliance, measurable outcomes	Symbolic coherence, stakeholder trust
Execution Quality Indicators	Reduced Latency, expanded scope, efficiency gains	Identity preservation, stakeholder alignment, legitimacy

When GenAI capabilities grounded in efficiency logic are introduced into brand-driven organizations governed by identity logic, predictable tensions emerge. The following sections develop the dominant assumptions in GenAI-execution literature.

2.3 Generative AI and Strategy Execution: Dominant Assumptions

2.3.1 From Automation to Reconfiguration

Early AI perspectives focused primarily on task automation and process optimization (Davenport & Ronanki, 2018). GenAI, however, represents a qualitative shift, reconfiguring the fundamental mechanisms through which organizations sense, interpret, decide, and act (Laamanen et al., 2025; Neiroukh et al., 2024).

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This shift is conceptualized through an attention-based view, treating execution as continuous cycles of sensing, interpreting, deciding, and acting, rather than a linear sequence following a formulation (Laamanen et al., 2025; Ocasio, 1997). GenAI expands organizational attention by broadening the range of issues firms can simultaneously attend to, accelerating feedback loops, and redistributing attention across different actors. Execution challenges are understood as problems of bounded attention; organizations fail to execute because they cannot monitor enough issues, process information quickly enough, or coordinate action effectively (Ocasio, 1997). GenAI is positioned to alleviate these constraints.

Academic and practitioner reports converge remarkably on this framing. Industry reports consistently stress GenAI's value in accelerating decisions, enhancing analytics, and improving coordination (Deloitte, 2025; McKinsey & Company, 2025). This mutual reinforcement may naturalize particular execution logics, crowding out alternatives (Brown et al., 2024). This convergence occurs despite limited empirical grounding. Brown et al. (2024) observe that GenAI research in business and management remains largely hypothetical, projecting potential impacts rather than documenting realized outcomes. Current frameworks may represent aspirational projections rather than empirically validated mechanisms.

Three core assumptions structure this efficiency-oriented framing of GenAI-enabled execution. These assumptions do not deny the relevance of human judgment, interpretive processes, or relational dynamics. Rather, they position these elements as supporting conditions for realizing speed, analytical breadth, and coordination benefits, not as constitutive dimensions of execution quality in their own right. (note: Insert table of assumption after this)

2.3.2 Assumption 1: Execution Quality improves with Acceleration & Analytics

A central assumption in GenAI execution literature is that execution quality increases as decision cycles become faster and analytical evaluation more comprehensive. This dual focus treats temporal compression and analytical breadth as universally beneficial, positioning GenAI as uniquely capable of advancing both simultaneously.

Temporal Acceleration as Quality Enhancement: Execution problems are described as delays in issue recognition, evaluation, and response. GenAI improves execution by compressing recognition-to-action cycles and reducing latency (Laamanen et al., 2025). Speed is treated as constitutive of execution quality, with faster cycles assumed to strengthen the connection between

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Commented [JL18]: Yes, this is seminal work, but you can't just jump back 30 years and skip everything in-between !!

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strategic intent and action. Empirical studies associate AI adoption with accelerated decision-making and increased organizational responsiveness (Al-Surmi et al., 2022; Neiroukh et al., 2024). However, these studies measure speed improvements without examining whether faster decisions improve execution outcomes in contexts where decision quality depends on deliberation, stakeholder consultation, or symbolic coherence.

Analytical Optimization as Decision Enhancement: Complementing temporal acceleration, GenAI is assumed to improve execution by enhancing the analytical quality of decision-making. Decision quality is framed as a function of data comprehensiveness, pattern recognition, and systematic evaluation of alternatives (Shrestha et al., 2019). GenAI can process vast volumes of information, identify patterns that humans miss, and evaluate multiple alternatives with greater consistency than human decision makers. Doshi et al. (2025) also demonstrate that GenAI can provide predictive assessments across multiple scenarios, reducing bias and inconsistency. Improved execution is assumed to follow better-informed choices derived specifically from more extensive analysis.

Laamanen et al. (2025) provide theoretical depth to this assumption through organizational attention, arguing that GenAI expands and redistributes where organizations direct attention, allowing firms to monitor more issues simultaneously and act more quickly with reduced temporal lag. While this attention-based framing adds conceptual depth, it continues to treat temporal and analytical intensification as core indicators of improved execution, privileging quantifiable, pattern-based, and analytically derivable knowledge while backgrounding interpretive judgment, tacit understanding, and contextual wisdom.

2.3.3 Assumption 2: Execution Challenges are Primarily Structural and Designable

A second assumption is that GenAI integration challenges are primarily technical or structural in nature and can be addressed through appropriate organizational design. This assumption does not ignore the relational or interpretive dimensions but positions them as manageable through structural mechanisms such as governance frameworks to accommodate meaning-making needs, role clarity to resolve coordination tensions, and capability development to address interpretive gaps.

This structural framing is prominent across the literature. Vera et al. (2026) describe GenAI as a socio-technical intermediary that reshapes coordination patterns, authority structures, and

managerial roles, with challenges such as coordination breakdowns, ambiguity in accountability, and reduced oversight, mitigated through governance frameworks and clarified decision right. Shrestha et al. (2019) demonstrate that alternative decision architectures, such as full delegation, hybrid sequencing, or the aggregation of human and AI inputs, can address differences in speed, consistency, and interpretive capacity between human and machine judgment.

This design-oriented assumption reflects a systems engineering perspective in which organizational problems are decomposable into structural elements that can be optimized independently (Simon, 1962). However, this framing prioritizes architectural intervention over interpretive or relational considerations. It treats coordination as primarily a structural phenomenon rather than an ongoing accomplishment requiring continuous meaning maintenance (Weick, 1995). Whether this structural design can adequately address the challenges by contested meaning, legitimacy concerns, or identity incoherence remains underexplored, particularly where execution depends on symbolic alignment rather than procedural compliance.

2.3.4 Assumption 3: Human-AI Collaboration is Achievable & Stabilizable through Design

A third assumption holds that human-AI collaboration is achievable and stable, once appropriate design and governance mechanisms are implemented. The literature acknowledges that collaboration is complex and requires ongoing attention. However, the dominant framing treats collaboration challenges as addressable through deliberate role specification, interface design, and coordination routines. Collaboration is positioned as an outcome of design choices rather than as an ongoing, fragile accomplishment needing continuous relational maintenance beyond structural configuration.

GenAI introduces hybrid forms of agency that reshape how work is distributed between human and machine actors (Vera et al., 2026). The focus is on establishing clear boundaries, specifying decision rights, creating escalation protocols, and designing interfaces that support complementary contributions. Shrestha et al. (2019) argue that clear decision rights and escalation rules can maintain accountability even when delegating to opaque AI systems, assuming accountability is primarily procedural, rather than symbolic or relational.

However, recent empirical work challenges this assumption. Zheng et al. (2025), find that many AI initiatives underperform not because of technical limitations but because of failures in human coordination. Collaboration breaks down when humans and AI pursue divergent goals, when

information loses meaning as it moves between human and algorithmic processing, or when the continuous interpretive work required to maintain shared understanding is neglected. This finding suggests that structural configuration may be necessary but insufficient for effective human-AI collaboration, particularly when execution depends on shared interpretive frameworks rather than procedural compliance. Additionally, as AI systems become more central yet less interpretable, operating through complex pattern recognition processes that resist transparent explanation (Shrestha et al., 2019), accountability becomes problematic, as it requires explaining not just decision logic but appropriateness given organizational identity.

2.3.5 Synthesis: An Efficiency-Oriented Logic of Execution

The three assumptions analyzed above are based on the efficiency-oriented logic of strategy execution, conceptualizing execution as a function of temporal acceleration, analytical optimization, and structurally stabilized coordination. These assumptions are mutually reinforcing, as acceleration creates demand for structural governance to manage decision velocity, analytical optimization requires human-AI collaboration mechanisms to integrate insights into human decision-making, and structural design provides the architecture within which collaboration operates. Together, they form a coherent framework that positions GenAI as an execution-enhancing technology.

However, this synthesis also reveals potential boundary conditions. Each assumption privileges particular dimensions of execution while backgrounding others, such as interpretive coherence, symbolic consistency, and identity alignment. The literature offers limited insight into how these assumptions operate in organizational contexts where execution quality is evaluated through criteria beyond efficiency and optimization. The following section examines such contexts by articulating three theoretical tensions that emerge when GenAI capabilities grounded in efficient logic are introduced into brand-driven organizations governed by identity logic.

2.4 Theoretical Tensions: Efficiency Logic vs Identity Logic in Execution

The assumptions identified in Section 2.3 reflect an efficiency-oriented understanding of strategy execution. However, as established in Section 2.2, brand-driven organizations operate under an identity logic alongside operational performance. When these logics collide, three systematic tensions emerge: temporal, epistemic, and relational. The following section develops each tension.

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Commented [JL25]: I like this a lot - BUT the problem is that we are already halfway through p.9 before we start seeing anything interesting 😊 The good news are that I can now see how the logics lens makes sense. (Though I could also see that this could be a mismatch of practice - what AI does and what we are trying to do are two different things). Either way, you should start the paper with a statement of mismatched logics or practices - Then build that argument structurally.

Commented [JL26]: How is this a theoretical rather than a practice-based tension?

Commented [JL27]: What about other logics? E.g., effectiveness, etc? I would suggest you draw out the different logics, then focus on one (identity), using your case (brand org) to illustrate.

Commented [JL28]: Operational is not necessarily strategic. You have to be very careful in your language here and make sure you stay at the same level of analysis. Easier to talk about how different logics clash.

Commented [JL29]: These tensions could point to a fourth theoretical lens - dialectics, paradox, etc. Why do we need these tensions? Could they just be disconnects? Mismatched assumptions? I would keep the theory and language cleaner.

2.4.1 Temporal Tensions: Acceleration vs Deliberate Pacing

GenAI execution frameworks emphasize speed and responsiveness as core indicators of execution quality, assuming that faster decision cycles strengthen the link between strategic intent and organizational action (Laamanen et al., 2025; Neiroukh et al., 2024). However, Brand-driven execution operates according to a different temporal logic. Brand equity accumulates through the consistency of meaning over time, reinforced by sustained coherence across touchpoints (Aaker, 1991; Keller, 1993).

Empirical evidence supports this distinction. Brand-driven organizations engage in deliberate pacing of execution to allow for stakeholder consultation, interpretive alignment, and verification of symbolic coherence (Hatch & Schultz, 2002; Vallaster & Wallpach, 2013). Luxury firms deliberately slow technology adoption to protect exclusivity and heritage-based legitimacy (Kapferer & Bastien, 2009), while identity change research demonstrates that successful adaptation requires extended sensemaking periods that cannot be compressed without risking incoherence (Gioia et al., 2000).

This creates fundamental temporal tension: GenAI enables rapid sensing and action, while brand-driven execution requires slower, deliberative processes to maintain identity coherence. Decisions that would be analytically optimal if implemented immediately violate identity if they outpace stakeholder understanding.

Theoretical expectation 1: *In brand-driven organizations, the temporal acceleration enabled by GenAI may create tensions with deliberate pacing requirements for identity coherence, potentially positioning speed and symbolic legitimacy as competing rather than complementary execution criteria.*

2.4.2 Epistemic Tensions: Analytical Optimization vs Interpretive Judgement

GenAI execution frameworks equate decision quality with analytical optimization, data comprehensiveness, predictive accuracy, and systematic evaluation of alternatives (Doshi et al., 2025; Shrestha et al., 2019). Brand-driven decision-making, however, relies on interpretive judgment. Decisions are evaluated for appropriateness relative to identity narratives and stakeholder expectations drawn on tacit, context-specific knowledge (Gioia et al., 2013; Weick, 1995).

Commented [JL30]: This is an interpretivist thesis, which does not make theoretical claims, but rather points to potential theoretical divergence. Therefore, please avoid hypotheses,

Empirical research shows that attractive brand extensions can damage core association when they violate perceived identity fit, even when market analysis suggests gains (Aaker & Keller, 1990). Luxury brands reject efficiency-enhancing operations when they threaten perceptions of authenticity, despite operational improvements (Beverland, 2005). Modernization decisions justified by consumer trends can erode heritage equity (Urde et al., 2007). The “rightness” of such decisions depends on interpretive judgment about whether changes preserve or violate brand essence, determinations that cannot be made through data analysis alone.

This epistemic tension surfaces when GenAI excels at pattern recognition but struggles with context-specific interpretation, tacit knowledge, and symbolic meaning (Faraj et al., 2018). Brand decisions often depend on subtle aesthetic judgements and cultural sensitivity that resist quantification (Holt, 2004). Research on tacit knowledge demonstrates that much strategic knowledge is embodied in practice and difficult to articulate, making analytical optimization alone insufficient when decisions require the use of both tacit and explicit knowledge (Spender, 1996).

Theoretical expectation 2: *In brand-driven organizations, GenAI’s analytical optimization may create tensions with interpretive judgment requirements, potentially positioning data-driven decision making and identity-based appropriateness assessments as competing in evaluation frameworks rather than complementary inputs.*

2.4.3 Relational Tensions: Structural Governance vs. Ongoing Meaning Maintenance

GenAI execution frameworks assume that coordination, collaboration, and accountability challenges can be addressed through governance mechanisms, role specification, and formal controls (Shrestha et al., 2019; Vera et al., 2026). Brand-driven execution, however, depends on continuous meaning maintenance across organizational actors. Brand consistency emerges through ongoing relational work, such as dialogue, alignment, and collective sensemaking, rather than procedural control alone (Iglesias & Ind, 2020; Vallaster & de Chernatony, 2006).

Empirical research on human-AI collaboration highlights how meaning degrades as information moves between human and algorithmic actors. AI systems process information in ways that strip context, reframe problems algorithmically, and generate outputs requiring reinterpretation, creating opportunities for meaning loss (Zheng et al., 2025). When GenAI recommends actions

based on pattern recognition without understanding brand heritage, implementation may violate identity and lose significance despite analytical soundness.

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Research on accountability in identity-based organizations reveals that accountability is fundamentally interpretive rather than merely procedural (Balmer, 2017; Gioia et al., 2013). Stakeholders hold organizations accountable for whether decisions align with identity commitments, requiring explanation of decision meaning, not just decision logic. When GenAI contributes to decisions, this interpretive accountability becomes more complex, as opaque algorithmic processes resist explanation in identity-relevant terms (Ravasi & Schultz, 2006).

Theoretical Expectation 3: *In brand-driven organizations, structural governance mechanisms for GenAI integration may prove insufficient for maintaining the continuous meaning-making and interpretive accountability required for identity-coherent execution, potentially creating implementation-legitimacy gaps.*

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2.4.4 Synthesis: Systematic Logic Collision

Collectively, these temporal, epistemic, and relational tensions reflect a systematic clash between efficiency-oriented and identity-driven execution logics. While GenAI-execution frameworks assume that execution quality improves through speed, analytics, and structural control, brand-driven organizations evaluate execution through coherence, legitimacy, and preservation of meaning.

These tensions are not merely operational challenges but fundamental contradictions in what constitutes “good” execution. They suggest that mechanisms that are said to improve execution in efficiency-oriented contexts may introduce trade-offs or create implementation risks in identity-oriented contexts. Whether these tensions result in conflicts, trade-offs, or opportunities for productive adaptation remains an empirical question to be investigated in practice. (Note: insert table to summarize tensions)

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2.5 Research Gap and Study Positioning

2.5.1 The Empirical and Theoretical Gap

This literature review reveals a significant gap at the intersection of GenAI-enabled strategy execution and brand-driven organizational contexts. Despite strong theoretical grounding for

systematic tensions between efficiency and identity logics, no empirical research has examined how these tensions manifest when GenAI is deployed in brand-driven organizations.

The empirical gap is threefold. First, we do not know whether the GenAI mechanisms theorized to improve execution (speed, analytical breadth, and coordination efficiency) align with the execution priorities in brand-driven organizations where identity coherence is central. Second, we do not understand how brand-driven organizations experience and negotiate temporal, epistemic, and relational tensions when deploying GenAI. It is unclear whether this happens through adaptation, constraint abandonment, or reconciliation. Third, we lack insight into conditions under which efficiency-oriented and identity-oriented logics can coexist versus prove incompatible, with no guidance on boundary conditions or contextual moderators.

The theoretical gap is equally significant. Current GenAI-execution theory builds on efficiency logic without examining whether this holds across organizational contexts. The frameworks may be incomplete and validated only in settings where efficiency is the primary execution criterion. Extending them to identity-oriented contexts requires theoretical development to account for alternative execution logics. Brown et al. (2024) call for precisely this theory-driven empirical investigation, arguing that GenAI research must move beyond efficiency assumptions to understand how AI reshapes the meaning and practice of core organizational processes.

2.5.2 Guiding Research Questions

The literature review and theoretical development motivate two primary research questions:

RQ1: *How are GenAI-execution assumptions enacted experiences, and potentially contested when GenAI is deployed for strategy execution in brand-driven organizations?*

This question examines whether and how theoretically expected tensions appear in practice, focusing on how organizational actors experience GenAI deployment, the assumptions built into the implementation choices, and situations where efficiency-driven mechanisms clash with identity-related constraints.

RQ2: *How do brand-driven organizations manage trade-offs between efficiency-oriented GenAI mechanisms and identity-oriented execution priorities?*

This question examines how organizations respond to tensions, whether through adaptation strategies, constraint mechanisms, reconciliation practices, or deployment limits. It also seeks to

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Commented [JL35]: And why would we? This is very specific. So, rather than calling for that research specifically, you would use an illustrative example of these tensions, e.g., in a brand org.

Commented [JL36]: Not sure why we need this. You have already pointed to mismatch...

Commented [JL37]: The theoretical gap is about understanding how technology influences logics... or practice... or creates tensions between them. This here is still quite empirical.

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find what factors influence whether these tensions are intensified or eased, and under what conditions efficiency and identity logics prove compatible versus incompatible.

Together, these questions guide an empirical investigation into the interaction between efficiency-oriented AI capabilities and identity-oriented organizational priorities in strategy execution. The following chapter describes the qualitative research design used to study these questions.

Analyzing Assumptions of Generative AI

Interview Script

Part 1: Organizational Context and Role

1. **Role and Responsibilities:** Can you briefly describe your current role and main responsibilities?

Probes:

- How long have you been in this role?
- Involvement in strategy (execution)
- Involvement with AI

Part 2: GenAI and Strategy Execution

2. How does your organization typically approach strategy execution? → what does the process look like and how is success defined?

→ Can you walk me through a recent example where GenAI played a role? Impact on aforementioned criteria (...speed, consistency, brand fit, quality...)

Overall, what has the impact of AI been on the organization?

→ Any benefits or successes?

→ Any challenges or conflicts?

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Commented [JL40]: Restate their role. Explain that you know a bit about what they do already, but would like to hear it in their own words to confirm understanding. Otherwise they may ask you to just look it up or think you did not prepare for the interview..

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describe the role of the brand in guiding decision-making within your organization?
How important is brand alignment in execution decisions?
approvals?
involvement with generative AI initiatives in your organization?
What tools or systems are being used?
In which process is GenAI involved?

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Probes:

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decision where GenAI played a role?
Probes:
How was GenAI used?
What happened with its output?
Evaluating Execution Quality: What criteria does your organization use to judge whether execution goes well?
Probes:
What matters most: speed, consistency, brand fit, results?
evaluated?

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affected the speed at which strategic decisions are made or extended?
In what are has it accelerated processes?
Has this generally been positive, negative, or mixed?
Deliberate Pacing: Are there situations in which your organization deliberately slows down decision-making, even when GenAI enables faster action?

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Part 3: Reflection and Closing

3. **Opportunities:** Looking ahead, what do you see as the main opportunities of using GenAI in strategy execution in your organization?
4. **Risks and Tensions:** What do you see as the main risks or tensions?
5. **Final thoughts:** Is there anything important about GenAI and brand-driven execution that we haven't discussed?

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provides a recommendation or generates content, how do you evaluate whether it is appropriate for the brand?

Probes:

What makes something "on brand" versus "off brand"?

Is that evaluation explicit or intuitive?

Conflicts between Data and Brand Judgement: Have there been instances where AI recommendations conflict with what felt right for the brand?

Probes:

What was the nature of the conflict?

How was it resolved?

Who made the final decision?

Strengths and Limitations of GenAI: What aspects of brand-related decisions does GenAI handle particularly well in your experience? Where does it struggle?

Probes:

What does it do better than human judgment?

What still requires human expertise?

Theme 4: Coordination and Accountability (RQ3)

Division of Responsibilities: How are responsibilities divided between humans and GenAI in execution processes?

Probes:

Who reviews or approves AI-supported outputs?

Are there formal governance structures?

Accountability: How is accountability handled when GenAI influences brand-related decisions?

Probes:

If something goes wrong, who is responsible?

Does the use of AI complicate accountability?

Maintaining shared understanding: How do you maintain shared understanding of what the brand means across your team when GenAI is involved in execution?

Probes:

Have there been challenges in maintaining brand consistency with AI?

Do AI outputs sometimes need revision to fit the brand?

How often does this happen?

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You have too many leading questions here. Use open questions to avoid that. Use lots of prompts to fill out content - give me an example, illustrate that, explain in greater detail, tell me more, etc.